# User Manual

**Find your role. Read that chapter. Read the orientation first if it is your first day.**

## Start here

**Getting started** — signing in, two-factor, branches, the language switch, and the five behaviours of this system that will otherwise surprise you. Twenty minutes, once.

## Then your role

| IF YOU ARE | READ | YOU WILL SPEND MOST OF YOUR TIME IN |
|---|---|---|
| Moving shipments day to day | **Coordinator** | Dashboard, Shipments, Enquiries |
| Running the operation | **Operations Manager** | Dashboard, Exceptions, Rate cards |
| Answering enquiries and quoting | **Sales** | Enquiries, Quotations |
| Invoicing and chasing money | **Finance** | Finance overview, Invoices, Payments, Payables |
| Clearing cargo | **Customs Broker** | Customs |
| Running the system itself | **Administrator** | Settings |

Chapters are cumulative where roles are: the operations manager's chapter assumes you have read the coordinator's, and does not repeat it.

## To hand out

These two are written to be sent under your own brand. They name no software and carry no supplier logo. Replace the bracketed tokens at the top and delete the note.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Tracking your shipments** | **For your customers.** The public tracking page and the portal. |
| **Agents and partners** | **Read this yourself first.** The agent portal is a scaffold in this release, and this chapter says what to tell an agent in the meantime. |

## Reference

**Who can do what** — the full permission matrix, the four deliberate separations of duty, and the answers to the questions an auditor asks. Keep this to hand before granting anyone a role.

## What is not in this release

Collected in one place so nobody spends an afternoon looking:

| | STATUS |
|---|---|
| Automatic carrier tracking feeds | **Configurable, off by default.** Carrier-direct feeds (Maersk, Hapag-Lloyd, CMA CGM) are switched on under *Settings → Integrations → Container tracking*, each with the carrier's own registration. Until then, milestones are entered by your team. |
| Direct customs filing, Kuwait | **Not planned.** Declarations are tracked, not filed. A duty *estimate* is available; the assessment is still recorded by hand. |
| UAE MPCI filing | Roadmap |
| Saudi ZATCA e-invoicing | Roadmap. *Settings → Integrations → E-invoice transmission* exists, but no accredited provider is connected. |
| Agent portal — RFQ response, agent posting | In delivery. Route scoped, screens not built. |
| Email notifications | **Live** once *Outbound mail* is configured under *Settings → Integrations*. Wording is edited under *Settings → Notification wording*. |
| WhatsApp notifications | Not in this release. |
| Scheduled email reports | In delivery. Every screen exports today; the margin report exports CSV. |
| Accounting-package connectors | Journal export per period from *Finance → Overview* today; direct connectors later. |
| Self-service password reset | **Available** — *Forgotten your password?* on the sign-in page — once *Outbound mail* is configured. Otherwise the administrator resets from a shell. |
| A user-invitation screen | *Settings → Users & roles → Invite someone* creates the person and their branch roles. The sign-in credential is still created from a shell. |

**If your supplier tells you one of these has shipped, ask to see it on your own deployment.** This table is maintained against the working software rather than against a plan.

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## Conventions in these chapters

| | |
|---|---|
| **Screen names** | Written as they appear: *Operations → Customs* |
| **Permission keys** | In `code`, e.g. `invoice.issue` — send the key to your administrator, not a description of the screen |
| **In delivery** | Scaffolded, being finished, has a release |
| **Not planned** | Will not be built, with the reason given |

Nothing in this manual describes a capability the software does not have. Where a chapter would naturally describe one, it says so instead — chapter 8 is the clearest example, and it is the model for the rest.

# Getting started

**Read this once, on your first day. Then go to the chapter for your role.**

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## 1. Signing in

Go to your company's Cargolane address — it is on your own domain, something like `ops.yourcompany.com`. You will see a sign-in page with your company's logo on it.

**There is no sign-up form, and this is deliberate.** Accounts are created by your administrator. If you do not have one, you are asking the wrong person for software — ask the person who runs your systems.

### If you are an Administrator or work in Finance

You will be asked to set up **two-factor authentication** the first time you sign in. Install an authenticator app on your phone — Google Authenticator, Microsoft Authenticator, 1Password or similar — scan the code on screen, and enter the six-digit number it shows you.

From then on you need your password *and* your phone to sign in.

This is required, not optional, for those two roles. They are the two that can change who has access and can issue money documents.

### If you have forgotten your password

**Forgotten your password?** on the sign-in page sends a link to set a new one. The link expires in one hour, and it only arrives if your deployment's outbound mail has been configured. If nothing arrives, ask your administrator — they can reset it from the server, and they will give you the new one directly rather than emailing it.

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## 2. Finding your way around

The screen has three parts and they do not move.

**Down the left, the navigation**, in four groups. The groups match how a forwarding office is actually organised, rather than how the software is built:

| GROUP | WHAT IS IN IT |
|---|---|
| **Commercial** | Dashboard · Enquiries · Quotations · Customers · Rate cards |
| **Operations** | Shipments · Exceptions · Consolidations · Customs · Documents · Assistant |
| **Network** | Partners & agents · Ports & places · Reference data · Bulk import |
| **Finance** | Overview · Invoices · Payments · Payables · Settlements · Reports |

**You will not be able to do all of it.** Two entries are hidden outright: **Reports** needs `report.read`, and **Assistant** appears only once your administrator has configured a model key. Every other screen is listed for every internal role, and what your role permits shows up on the screen itself — a button you do not hold the

permission for is not offered, and a screen that is wholly somebody else's says which permission it needs. This is not a limitation on you personally — it is how the separation of duties works, and every role's exact permissions are listed in `09-permissions-reference.md`.

**Across the top**, the search box — references, container numbers, master and house bill numbers, customers — the appearance switch and the language switch.

**At the foot of the navigation**, your name, your role and how many branches you hold; the **Customer tracking** link; and — if your role includes it — **Settings**.

**In the middle**, the screen you are on. Once a model key is configured, a floating **Assistant** button sits in the bottom corner of every screen as well.

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## 3. Branches

Everything in the system belongs to a branch — a shipment, a customer, an invoice, a rate card.

**You see the branches you hold a role in, and only those.** If you work in the Kuwait office you see Kuwait's shipments. If you hold a role in both Kuwait and Dubai, you see both, and screens that count things count both.

If you ask for something in a branch you do not have a role in, the system says **not found** — not "access denied". That is intentional: it does not confirm that the record exists.

**You cannot widen your own access.** Only an administrator can give you a role in another branch.

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## 4. Arabic and English

The language switch is at the top of every screen. It changes the entire interface, including the direction of the layout, and it changes documents and the customer-facing pages too.

Your choice is remembered. Your colleague's choice is theirs — two people can use the same system in different languages at the same time, on the same data.

**Your customers get the same choice**, on the tracking page and in the portal, without an account.

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## 5. Five things about how this system behaves

These are unusual enough to be worth knowing on day one, because each of them will otherwise surprise you.

### Nothing is deleted

There is no delete button, anywhere, on anything that matters. Records are **closed**, **cancelled**, **superseded** or **deactivated** — and they stay visible.

A quotation you revise does not overwrite the old one; the old one is marked superseded and remains readable. A document you replace keeps its earlier version. This is what makes the system usable as evidence six months later, when somebody asks what you actually sent.

If something is cluttering a list, filter it — do not look for a way to remove it.

### Everything is recorded

Every change is written to an audit log by the database itself: who, when, what changed, from which address. It records changes that go around the application as well as those made through it.

**Nobody can edit or delete an entry** — not your administrator, not your supplier's support engineers. The permission to do so does not exist on any account.

This is protection, not surveillance. When something goes wrong on a shipment, the trail shows what actually happened rather than what everyone remembers.

### Money is exact, and currency-aware

Amounts are held exactly, and rounded per currency at the line. The Kuwaiti dinar carries three decimal places and the system knows it — it does not round your dinars as though they were dollars.

Every charge line stores the exchange rate that was used **and the moment it was taken**. A job quoted in dollars and invoiced in dinars still reconciles months later, because the rate is recorded rather than recalculated.

### Time is measured against a working calendar

Response deadlines and clearance windows count working days on the calendar configured for that branch — Sunday to Thursday, with public holidays — not calendar days. An enquiry that arrives on Thursday afternoon is not overdue on Saturday morning.

### The system tells you what is wrong first

Lists that show problems — exceptions, overdue enquiries, unpaid invoices — are ordered **oldest first**, not newest first. The logic is stated on the screens themselves: *the one nobody has looked at is the one the process missed.*

Resist the urge to sort by newest. The newest problem is the one that is already being handled.

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## 6. Things you can see from anywhere

| | |
|---|---|
| **Customer tracking** | Opens the public tracking page — the same page your customer sees. Useful for checking what a customer is actually looking at before you ring them back. |
| **Search** | The box at the top of every screen. A reference, a container number, a master or house bill number, a booking number, a customer's own reference or a customer name — across every shipment you can see. |
| **Assistant** | The floating button in the bottom corner, once a model key is configured. Ask it about your shipments, enquiries and invoices; it reads only what you can see and changes nothing — where an action makes sense it offers you the record to confirm on. **Operations** → **Assistant** is the same thing full-screen, with your past conversations kept. |
| **Settings** | Only if your role includes it. Users, branches, the audit log, vendor access, notification wording, API keys, mailboxes, integrations and branding. |

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## 7. If something looks wrong

**A screen says you cannot view it.** Your role does not include that permission. The message names the permission. Send the name to your administrator rather than describing the screen.

**A record you expected is not there.** Check the branch filter, and check whether you hold a role in the branch it belongs to.

**A number looks wrong.** Do not correct it by overwriting something. Open the record and look at its history — the audit trail will show what changed and when, and the answer is usually there.

**Something is genuinely broken.** Tell your administrator, with the shipment reference or invoice number and the time it happened. Both are what makes it findable.

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## 8. What is not in this release

Said here once so that nobody spends an afternoon looking for it:

| | |
|---|---|
| **Automatic carrier tracking** | Off unless your administrator switches it on. Carrier-direct feeds from Maersk, Hapag-Lloyd and CMA CGM are configured under *Settings → Integrations → Container tracking*, and each needs the carrier's own registration. Until then, milestones are entered by your team. |
| **Direct customs filing** | Declarations are tracked, not filed. You file where you file today and record the reference here. |
| **WhatsApp notifications** | Not in this release. |
| **Email notifications** | Live once *Outbound mail* is configured under *Settings → Integrations*. The wording of each message is edited under *Settings → Notification wording*, in both languages. |
| **Scheduled reports by email** | In delivery. Every screen exports today. |
| **Accounting-package integration** | A journal export per period, from *Finance → Overview*; direct connectors later. |
| **The agent portal** | The route exists and is correctly scoped, but the screens are not built. Do not give an agent a login yet — see `08-agent-portal.md`. |

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**Next:** find your role.

| ROLE | CHAPTER |
|---|---|
| Coordinator | `01-coordinator.md` |
| Operations Manager | `02-operations-manager.md` |
| Sales | `03-sales.md` |
| Finance | `04-finance.md` |
| Customs Broker | `05-customs-broker.md` |

| ROLE | CHAPTER |
| --- | --- |
| Administrator | `06-administrator.md` |

# Coordinator

**You move shipments. This chapter is the whole of your day.**

> Read `00-orientation.md` first if you have not. It covers signing in, branches and the five behaviours that will otherwise surprise you.

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## Your day, in order

Open the **Dashboard**. It opens on the things that need you, and there is a line at the top telling you how many there are. If it says nothing needs you, that is a real statement and not a placeholder — every open shipment is running to plan.

Then work in this order. It is the order the screens are built for.

1. **Needs your attention** — exceptions on live shipments, oldest first
2. **Overdue replies** — enquiries past their reply deadline
3. **Arriving this week** — what lands, and what you must have ready before it does
4. **Demurrage accruing** — containers past their free days, costing money now

Everything below is how to handle each of those.

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## Enquiries

### Taking an enquiry

**Enquiries → New enquiry.** Enquiries also arrive by email — mail to a mailbox your administrator has connected becomes an enquiry for that branch within a minute — and those appear in the queue already, marked as unassigned, with *Email* as the channel.

If document extraction is switched on, an emailed enquiry opens with a panel headed **Read from the email**: the mode, lane, commodity, weight and the rest, as the assistant read them off the mail, each with the line it was read from. **Accept** the ones that are right and **Dismiss** the ones that are not; nothing is written to the enquiry until you do. A proposal with *No line quoted* is one to check against the mail before accepting.

What you must capture:

| FIELD | WHY IT MATTERS |
|---|---|
| **Customer** | Start typing — the list is your customer register. If they are new, create them (you have permission). |
| **Mode and direction** | Sea FCL, sea LCL, air, land or courier; import, export or cross-trade. This decides which rates apply and which milestones the job will get later. |
| **Origin and destination** | From the ports and places register. If a place is missing, ask your operations manager to add it — do not approximate with a nearby port. |
| **Cargo** | Weight, volume, pieces, commodity. For air and LCL these decide the chargeable weight, so an estimate here becomes a wrong price later. |

| FIELD | WHY IT MATTERS |
|---|---|
| **Required by** | Feeds the reply deadline. |

**Assign an owner.** An enquiry with no owner has nobody's name against the clock, and it is the single most common way an enquiry is lost. You can assign it to yourself.

## The clock

Every enquiry has a reply deadline, counted in **working hours on your branch's calendar**. The dashboard shows what has breached and what is due today, and the SLA watch list is ordered by whichever is closest to breaching.

**You cannot stop the clock by looking at the enquiry.** It stops when a quotation is sent, or when you press **Mark replied** to record a reply you made outside the system — by phone, say. That records the time of your first reply, which is what the deadline is measured against, and it cannot be undone. If an enquiry cannot be answered — the customer has gone quiet, the cargo does not exist — that is a *close*, and closing is your operations manager's or the sales team's decision, not yours. Say so rather than leaving it to breach silently.

**Start rating** tells the queue somebody is on it. It does not stop the clock.

## Pricing it

Open the enquiry and press **Price it**. The system looks for a live rate card covering that lane, mode and validity date, and prices from it — chargeable weight is calculated for the mode, and accessorials come from the catalogue. The **Rate comparison** shows every option with buy, sell and margin side by side; the buy side and the margin are internal and never reach the customer.

**If there is no rate card for the lane**, you will be told so plainly rather than given a wrong number. That means the lane has no buying rate on file and somebody is about to price it from memory. Tell your operations manager — the rate-card screen has a whole panel for exactly this problem.

**If a rate looks wrong**, it is a rate-card problem and not something to correct by hand on this quotation. Fixing the card fixes every future quote; fixing this one fixes one and hides the fault.

## Sending the quotation

You can send a quotation and you can revise one. A revision **supersedes** the previous version rather than replacing it — the customer's copy of what you sent before is still recoverable, which matters on the day somebody disputes it.

The quotation itself is a PDF on your letterhead — **PDF (EN)** and **PDF (AR)** on the quotation page — with the branch's trading conditions and its list of what is not included printed on it.

**You cannot mark a quotation accepted or rejected, or close an enquiry as won or lost.** That is the sales team's or the operations manager's call. When a customer accepts, tell whoever owns that enquiry so it is recorded properly — a job booked against an enquiry that was never closed leaves your branch's win rate wrong.

# Shipments

## Booking

A job normally begins from an accepted quotation, so the rates come with it and what you sold is what you costed. You can also create one directly with **New shipment**.

**Move it on** to *Booked* to take it out of draft. Booking is where the milestone template is applied — the checklist of stages for that mode and direction. Get the mode and direction right *before* booking; they decide the milestones.

**Booking checks the customer's credit.** A customer on credit hold, or one the shipment would put past their credit limit, cannot be booked. The message says which; the answer is a credit override on the customer's account, and that is your operations manager's or Finance's to record, not yours.

Capture the references as they arrive: master bill, house bill, booking number, vessel and voyage or flight number. **Add a container** for each box — number, type, seal — because a container is what a free-time clock runs against and what a proof of delivery is signed for.

**Engage a partner** under *Who is moving it*: the carrier, the agent at the far end, the haulier, the broker, the terminal — with their reference, so the number you quote when you ring them is on the file rather than in a mailbox. These are the companies you placed the work with, and who gets settled with; they are not the shipper and consignee on the bill. Those go under *Who prints on the documents*, below.

**Container and bill numbers are what your customer types into the tracking page.** A missing container number is a customer who cannot track their own shipment and rings you instead. This is the single highest-value data-entry habit in the whole system.

## Milestones

Each shipment carries its stages with three dates: **planned**, **revised** and **actual**. All three are kept.

- **Planned** is what you expected at booking.
- **Revised** is what you expect now — update it when the carrier tells you the vessel has slipped.
- **Actual** is what happened. Fill it when it happens, not at the end of the week.

The difference between planned and actual is what your management uses to work out where time is really going. Backfilling a week of dates on a Thursday afternoon produces a shipment that looks perfect and tells nobody anything.

**Record a milestone** sets the actual time on a step; **Take it back** clears a time recorded by mistake. The shipment's stage — departed, arrived, entered clearance, delivered — is set with **Move it on**, and the stages you can move it to are the ones offered; if a step you expect is not there, the shipment is not in the state you think it is.

## Putting a shipment on hold

You can place a shipment on hold and release it. Use it when a shipment has genuinely stopped — cargo not ready, payment held, documents missing — and it tells everyone else why.

**You cannot cancel a shipment, complete it or close it.** Those are your operations manager's. A shipment that should be cancelled goes to them with a reason, and the reason is the useful part.

## Exceptions

When something goes wrong, **Report a problem** on the shipment: what it is, how severe, who owns it, when it is due, and the cost impact if there is one. **Show the customer** puts it on their tracking page as a notice; turn it off for an internal-only note. **Resolve** closes it, and what you type under *What was done* is the only record of how it was fixed.

**Raise it even if you are about to fix it.** An exception that existed for two hours and was resolved is data about how often that happens; an exception that was fixed and never recorded is a pattern nobody can see. The number of times a lane goes wrong is what renegotiates the contract.

The exceptions screen lists everything open across live shipments, oldest first. Anything with nobody's name on it is flagged as unassigned.

## Free time

Containers past their free days accrue **demurrage**, **detention** or **storage** against the carrier's terms.

**Start a clock** when a box is discharged or collected — the kind (demurrage is the box at the port, detention is the box off it, storage is the warehouse), the container, the start date, and who the days are owed to. The free days and the per-diem come from your branch's free-time terms; change them only where this shipment's terms differ.

**From then on the clocks run themselves and write their own charge lines.** You do not have to calculate anything and you must not enter these charges by hand — you will duplicate them.

What you *do* have to do is enter the dates the clocks depend on: the start — discharge or gate out, whichever the kind counts from — and the **Ends** date when the box leaves the terminal or comes back to the line. Setting the end stops the accrual; charged days stay. A clock with no end date is a detention clock that never stops, which produces a wrong charge and a customer argument you will lose.

The shipment shows free days, chargeable days, per-diem rate, and what has accrued so far. So does the dashboard, in total, at the top.

## Proof of delivery

When the cargo changes hands, **Capture delivery** on the shipment — on a phone at the door, ideally. Who received it, when, which container or the whole shipment, a signature drawn with a finger, photographs of the cargo and the signed paper, and the device's location if it offers one. If something was short, damaged or refused, tick **Something was wrong** and say what: the delivery is still recorded, and that note is what a claim is argued from.

A mistake is corrected with **Correct this**. The original is kept and marked *Corrected*; nothing is overwritten.

## The charge ledger

The **Charge ledger** at the foot of the shipment is its P&L: every cost and every revenue line, with the margin. Costs arrive on their own from free-time clocks and consolidation splits, and you can **Add charge** for anything else — a buy is what the shipment costs you, a sell is what the customer is charged. Each line keeps the exchange rate it was struck at, so the figure never moves again.

## Customs

You can file and update the customs stage — **Update customs** records the declaration type and number, the broker, the clear-by date, and moves it through its statuses; the duty goes in as assessed.

**Estimate duty** gives you the landed cost before it ships: goods value, freight and insurance against the tariff loaded under Reference data, matched by the HS code on each cargo line. It is an estimate, not an assessment, and both are kept so the gap between them can be measured.

You cannot record the duty **payment**; that is Finance's, and the separation is deliberate.

If you are not the person who does clearance, that is your customs broker's chapter and you can leave it to them. See `05-customs-broker.md`.

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## Documents

Every file belongs to a shipment and has a **type** — bill of lading, invoice, packing list, certificate of origin, delivery order. **Operations → Documents** lists every one across your branches, newest first.

### What the documents are built from

Two panels on the shipment feed every document it produces, and both must be filled before anything is issued:

**Who prints on the documents — Add party** for the shipper, consignee, notify party, second notify, delivery agent and forwarding agent. Printed on the bill exactly as entered, in both languages, and kept as entered: a document records what was said, not what is currently true.

**What is in the shipment — Add cargo line** for each line of goods: description as the shipper declared it, marks and numbers, packages, HS code, gross and net weight, volume, and the container it is stuffed in. The packing list is grouped by container from these; the customs pack and the duty estimate read the HS codes.

### Issuing

**Issue and preview** on the shipment produces four documents:

| DOCUMENT | WHAT IT IS |
|---|---|
| **House bill of lading** — or **House air waybill** on an air shipment | Contract of carriage. Watermarked until numbered; the number comes from the branch's house B/L series, if one is set. |
| **Delivery order** | Expires seven days after issue. |
| **Packing list** | Grouped by container, with net weight. |
| **Customs declaration pack** | What the broker would otherwise retype. |

**EN** and **AR** preview the document in either language — a preview renders and stores nothing, so opening one costs nothing. **Issue** keeps the copy that was handed over: it stores the PDF, writes the document onto the shipment, and supersedes the previous version. Regenerating never replaces.

For a sea house bill that has been numbered, **Surrender bill** records a telex release: the shipper has handed the originals back and the agent releases without them. Copies print stamped from then on. It cannot be undone.

### Releasing

**Released or draft.** Released documents are visible to the customer, on the tracking page and in the portal. Drafts are not. **Release** is a decision you make per document, so nothing reaches a customer because somebody forgot the default — and it is not the same act as issuing. Issuing says *these bytes are the document*; releasing says *the customer now has it*.

**Issuing a new version supersedes the old one.** Both stay visible. Never work around the version by issuing a corrected document as something else — a shipment with two bills of lading and no relationship between them is exactly the confusion the versioning exists to prevent.

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## Customers

You can create and edit customers, and their contacts. Two habits are worth having from day one:

**Both names.** English and Arabic. The Arabic name is what appears on the Arabic quotation and the Arabic portal, and an entity with only an English name produces a document that reads half-translated to your customer.

**A real contact.** Name, email, phone. This is what the portal invitation and every notification uses.

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## Consolidations

**Operations → Consolidations.** Many house bills under one master, and the master's cost split between them.

**New consolidation** opens a master: mode, direction, port of loading and discharge, the carrier or co-loader, the master bill, booking, vessel and voyage or flight, ETD and ETA. The master bill belongs here, not on any house. Then **Attach** the shipments sailing under it — a house cannot join a master of a different mode — and **Detach** one that moves to another sailing. **Close manifest** at the cut-off.

**Could share a container**, at the foot of the consolidations screen, is the system doing this for you: loose LCL and air shipments on the same lane and sailing, grouped, with how full a container they would make. **Consolidate** opens the master with those houses already attached.

**Manifest** — and **AR** for the Arabic — is the PDF for the carrier and the far end.

**Add cost** records what the consolidation cost or earned as a whole — the basis decides how it divides across the houses. **Split** is not yours: it writes a cost line onto every house, which decides twenty margins, and it sits with your operations manager or Finance.

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## Supplier bills

When an agent, a line or a haulier bills you, you capture it — **Finance → Payables → Capture bill** — because you are the one who knows which of the thirty shipments on a monthly agent invoice each line belongs to. Enter the bill as it arrived, their lines as they wrote them, then **Match** each line to the cost line on the job it should settle.

**Read a bill** does the typing for you: upload the PDF or a photograph of the printout and the lines are captured for you to check. It lands as *Received*, like anything typed in. If the figures do not add up, nothing is written and the scan is kept on file; if no model key is configured, it says so and you capture the bill by hand.

Nothing you do here releases money. Approving a bill for payment, and paying it, are Finance's — see `04-finance.md`.

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## Bulk import

If you have arrived with a spreadsheet of customers, contacts, agents, ports or rates, use **Network → Bulk import** rather than typing them in. It checks every row before writing anything and imports nothing at all if any row fails.

Full instructions are in the administrator chapter, §Bulk import, and the same rules apply to you.

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## What you cannot do, and who to ask

| YOU WANT TO | ASK |
|---|---|
| Cancel or close a shipment | Operations Manager |
| Mark an enquiry won or lost | Operations Manager or Sales |
| Accept or reject a quotation | Operations Manager or Sales |
| Add or change a rate card | Operations Manager |
| Add an agent, haulier or carrier | Operations Manager |
| Add a port or place | Operations Manager |
| Let a customer book past their credit limit | Operations Manager or Finance |
| Split a consolidation's master cost across its houses | Operations Manager or Finance |
| Approve or pay a supplier's bill | Finance |
| Anything on an invoice or a receipt | Finance |
| Record duty paid | Finance |
| See the audit log | Administrator |
| Connect a mailbox | Administrator |
| Get access to another branch | Administrator |

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## Five habits that make the difference

1. **Enter the actual date on the day it happens.** Everything downstream — ETA, exceptions, free time, the customer's tracking page — is only as true as the last date somebody entered.
2. **Put the container and bill numbers in as soon as you have them.** They are how your customer finds their own shipment without ringing you.
3. **Raise the exception even when you are fixing it.**
4. **Never fix a wrong price on the quotation.** Fix the rate card.
5. **Never leave an enquiry unassigned overnight.** The clock is running against your branch either way.

# Operations Manager

**You hold everything a coordinator holds, plus the reversals, the rate cards and the reference data. This chapter covers the difference.**

> Read `00-orientation.md` and then `01-coordinator.md` — everything in the coordinator's chapter is yours too, and it is not repeated here.

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## What is yours alone

| | WHY IT SITS WITH YOU AND NOT BELOW YOU |
|---|---|
| **Cancel, complete and close shipments** | A coordinator moves work forward. Reversing it is an escalation, and it should cost a conversation. |
| **Close enquiries won or lost** | Win rate is a number that gets managed if the people measured on it can set it. |
| **Accept and reject quotations** | The commercial decision, not the administrative one. |
| **Write rate cards** | The pricing of every future quotation comes from here. |
| **Add agents, hauliers and carriers** | Your partner network is a register, not a free-text field. |
| **Add ports, places and reference data** | Deliberately operational, not administrative — see below. |
| **Read reports** | The dashboards, **Finance** → **Reports**, and every export. |

And three things you share with Finance, because each is a decision somebody has to own and the person who answers for the relationship is as often you as the accountant:

| | WHAT IT IS |
|---|---|
| **Split a consolidation's master cost** | Decides what every house under the master cost, and therefore every margin. A coordinator builds the master; splitting it is yours — see below. |
| **Let a customer trade past their credit limit** | Booking checks credit. A credit override is recorded on the customer, with a reason, and it is yours or Finance's — see below. |
| **Run a set-off with an agent** | Netting what an agent owes you against what you owe them. **Finance** → **Settlements**; the mechanics are in `04-finance.md`. |

**You cannot touch invoices.** Approving, issuing, voiding or crediting an invoice is Finance's alone, and an operations manager who could issue invoices is the segregation-of-duties failure an auditor asks about first. This is not an oversight and it is not configurable in the shipped role matrix. The same line runs through payables: you can capture a supplier's bill and match it against the job, and you cannot approve it for payment.

---

## Reading the dashboard properly

The dashboard is built to be read in one pass, top to bottom, and the order is the argument.

**The line at the top** tells you how many things need you today. When it says nothing does, believe it.

### The four numbers that mean something is wrong now

| | WHAT IT IS ACTUALLY TELLING YOU |
|---|---|
| **SLA breached** | Enquiries you promised to answer and have not. Not a backlog — a broken promise, and it is countable. |
| **Due today** | The ones about to join them. This is where a morning is well spent. |
| **Demurrage accruing** | Containers past their free days. This number is money leaving, per day, right now. |
| **Exceptions** | Everything wrong on live shipments, oldest first. |

**Oldest first is the whole point.** The newest exception has somebody looking at it. The one at the top of that list has been open longest, which usually means it belongs to nobody. Work down from the top, not up from the bottom.

### The four numbers that tell you how the business is running

| | HOW TO READ IT |
|---|---|
| **Win rate** | Quotes won against quotes sent this month. Falling win rate with stable volume is a pricing problem; falling volume with stable win rate is a demand problem. They need different responses. |
| **Average margin** | What you keep on a typical quotation before overheads. Watch it against win rate — a rising win rate and a falling margin means somebody is buying work. |
| **Median response** | Enquiry to quotation. The number your customers actually experience. Averages hide the bad days; this is the median for that reason. |
| **Enquiries received** | Fourteen days, with the previous week for comparison. |

### The rest

**Shipments by stage and by mode** — what is moving and how. **Busiest lanes** — by shipment count, which is where rate-card attention pays for itself. **Where the cargo is** — every live shipment drawn as a line; thicker means more of them.

**Arriving this week** is the one to check on a Sunday morning. Everything on it needs documents ready and clearance arranged before it lands, and the cost of finding out late is demurrage.

---

## Rate cards

**Network → Rate cards.** This screen is the most valuable one you own, and the subtitle states the case: *a lane with no live buying rate is a lane you are quoting blind.*

### The four numbers at the top

| | WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT |
|---|---|
| **Live rate cards** | Valid today. |
| **Lanes with a buying rate** | Distinct lanes you can price from a contract rather than from memory. |
| **Lanes priced blind** | **Start here.** You are shipping on these with no buying rate on file. Each one is a margin you are guessing. |
| **Expiring within 30 days** | Renew before the next quotation needs them, not after a customer notices. |

### Buy and sell

Cards come in two directions. A **buy** card is what an agent or carrier charges you and belongs to that partner. A **sell** card is what you publish, either to everyone or to a named customer.

**What each lane earns** pairs them by lane and shows the thinnest margins first. Those are the lanes to renegotiate — and it is a better list than the one you would write from memory, because it is ordered by fact.

### Validity, and the thing it prevents

Every card has validity dates, and the system makes **two overlapping cards on the same lane impossible** — not discouraged, impossible. If an import or an entry is rejected for overlapping an existing card, that is the protection working. Correct the dates on one of the two; do not work around it by creating the card under a slightly different lane.

This is the rule that stops two people quoting the same lane at two different prices in the same week.

### Loading a card

Small changes by hand. A carrier contract arriving as a spreadsheet goes through **Network → Bulk import** — see `06-administrator.md`. It checks every line before writing anything, and if a single line fails, nothing is written.

---

## Reference data — and why it is yours

**Network → Reference data**, plus **Network → Ports & places** for the locations. The screen lists the tables the rating, milestone and clearance engines read — and warns at the top about any that are empty, because an empty one fails silently three screens away as "no rate found":

| TABLE | WHAT IT DRIVES |
|---|---|
| **Charge types** | What can appear as a line on a quotation or an invoice, and the revenue and cost account each posts to |
| **Commodities**, **Container types**, **Incoterms**, **Document types**, **Exception codes** | The pickers everywhere else |
| **Milestone plans** | The steps a job of each shape — mode and direction — is booked with |
| **Working calendars** | Weekend, hours and closures, per branch — what every SLA, ageing and free-time clock counts against |

| TABLE | WHAT IT DRIVES |
|---|---|
| **Tariff** | Duty rates by HS prefix, for the duty estimate. Longest matching prefix wins; with none loaded, estimates fall back to the GCC common rate of 5%. |
| **Volumetric rules** | The divisor each mode's chargeable weight is billed on, and what it rounds to |
| **Free-time terms** | The days granted before demurrage starts, and the rate after — what a new clock is filled in from |

**This sits with operations rather than administration on purpose.** A shipment routed through a depot nobody has recorded cannot be booked until somebody records it. If that waits for an administrator, what actually happens is that somebody types the depot into a notes field — and the system grows a free-text "other" that swallows the data it was built to structure.

So you can add a port on the morning a new lane opens. The corresponding responsibility: **add it properly, once.** Two entries for the same port is worse than none, because every report silently splits between them.

### Milestone templates

The stages applied to a shipment when it is booked, per mode and direction.

**Name them the way your operations people say them out loud**, not the way a textbook does. If your team says "gate in", the milestone should say "gate in". People do not tick a checklist written in somebody else's vocabulary, and a milestone that is not ticked is a tracking page that lies to your customer.

### Working calendars

Sunday to Thursday, plus your public holidays, per branch. Every SLA clock and every ageing rule counts against this. **Load next year's holidays before January**, or every deadline over the break will be wrong in the same direction.

---

## Partners and agents

Agents, hauliers, carriers — with their people, the lanes they cover, their papers, and their account with you. Each partner's page carries:

| | |
|---|---|
| **People there** | Who to call. Kept on the partner, not in somebody's phone. |
| **Where they go** | The lanes this partner covers, by mode, with transit days. A partner with no lanes is never suggested for a quote. |
| **Papers** | Licences and certificates, with the date each lapses. |
| **Current account** | Link the partner to the customer record they invoice you as, and both directions of the relationship net into one balance. Needed before a set-off can be run. |
| **Bill tolerance** | How far this partner's bills may drift from what a job accrued before Finance is asked to look — a percentage, an absolute amount, or both; whichever is more generous applies. Leave both at zero and the charge type's own tolerance is used. |

**Keep the expiry dates real.** An agent whose trade licence expired four months ago is a compliance problem that surfaces during an audit rather than during the job, and the register is only worth having if the dates in it are true.

---

## Consolidations — splitting the master cost

A coordinator opens the master and attaches the houses; the mechanics are in `01-coordinator.md`. What is yours is **Split**: dividing each master-level cost across the houses under it, by volume, chargeable weight, gross weight, packages, equally, or stated by hand.

A split writes an ordinary charge line onto every house, so job profitability, invoicing and the accounting export need to know nothing about consolidation. **Reverse** posts the negative rather than deleting, because the lines may already sit on an issued invoice.

**Per-house margin is a fiction until the master cost is split.** A consolidation closed with its costs unsplit is twenty jobs whose margin is overstated by exactly the freight.

---

## Credit overrides

Booking a shipment checks the customer's credit standing for the branch: outstanding against limit, and whether they are on hold. A booking that would take them past the limit is refused, and the message says so.

The answer, when there is one, is **Record an override** on the customer's page — under *Standing and exceptions*, which shows the exposure, the limit, the headroom and every exception ever made. An override covers one shipment or one invoice, or everything for that customer until a date you give. The limit stays where it is; what is recorded is the exception, who made it, and why.

**The reason is the record.** Write a sentence somebody reviewing this in a year can act on. Not "approved".

---

## Notification wording

**Settings → Notification wording** is the one settings screen you hold, on the same permission as reference data, because it is the same kind of thing: what the product says when it writes to a customer or a colleague, editable without a release.

Each event — a shipment is booked, a milestone is reached, the ETA moves, a document is released, an invoice is issued or goes overdue, a quotation is sent or about to expire, an enquiry arrives or misses its SLA, an exception is raised, free time is running out, a rate card is about to lapse — has a subject and a message in both languages. **Reword** it for every entity, or for one branch alone, which overrides the default beneath it. The available merge fields are listed on the dialog; anything else sends as blank.

**What actually sends** is separate from the wording. Turning an event off there stops it being sent; the master switch, **Send notification email**, silences the whole channel, and every notification is still recorded, marked *Held back*. The **Delivery** log underneath shows every notification and what became of it, failures first.

---

## The reversals

### Cancelling a shipment

**Move it on** to *Cancelled* — available from draft, booked, in transit, on hold. It does not delete anything — the shipment stays, marked cancelled, with everything that happened to it intact.

**The reason is required, and it stays on the record.** In six months the question will be why, and the record is the only place that will still know.

### Completing and closing

**Complete** means operationally finished — delivered, nothing outstanding. **Close** means financially finished, and it is the last step. Closing a job whose costs have not all landed is how a lane's margin ends up looking better than it was; the accrued free-time charges in particular arrive after delivery.

Check the job's costs before you close it, not after.

### Releasing a hold

A held shipment returns to whichever stage it was in. Record why it was released in the exception that presumably caused it — a hold with no exception behind it is a decision nobody can reconstruct.

---

## What to look at, and when

| WHEN | WHAT | WHY |
|---|---|---|
| **Every morning** | Dashboard, top to bottom | Breached SLAs and the oldest exception |
| **Every morning** | Arriving this week | Documents and clearance, before it lands |
| **Twice a week** | Exceptions, oldest first | The top of that list is what nobody owns |
| **Weekly** | Demurrage accruing | Money leaving per day |
| **Weekly** | Rate cards — expiring within 30 days | Renew before a quotation needs it |
| **Monthly** | What each lane earns, thinnest first | The renegotiation list |
| **Monthly** | Win rate and average margin together | One without the other misleads |
| **Quarterly** | Lanes priced blind | Contracts to go and get |
| **Before January** | Working calendars | Next year's holidays |

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## Things worth refusing

**A coordinator asking you to fix a price on a quotation.** Fix the rate card. Fixing the quotation fixes one job and hides a fault that will produce ten more.

**A request for a free-text field.** Every one of them is a report that cannot be run. If the data has categories, it belongs in reference data where it can be counted.

**Closing a job to tidy the board.** The board is meant to show what is outstanding. A tidy board with open costs behind it is a management report that is wrong.

**Backfilled milestone dates.** A week of dates entered on Thursday is a shipment that looks perfect and tells you nothing — and a customer who watched the tracking page say nothing for four days.

# Sales

**You own the enquiry from the moment it arrives until it is won or lost.**

> Read `00-orientation.md` first.

---

## What you hold

Everything from enquiry to award, and nothing operational.

| YOU CAN | YOU CANNOT |
|---|---|
| Create, assign and price enquiries | Book or update a shipment |
| Send and revise quotations | Touch customs, documents or free time |
| **Accept and reject quotations** | Add or change a rate card |
| **Close an enquiry won, lost or cancelled** | Add an agent, haulier or carrier |
| Create and edit customers and contacts | Anything on an invoice or receipt |
| Read shipments — see what you sold, running | |
| Read the dashboards, the margin report, and export them | |

The two in bold are yours and not the coordinator's. You decide what was won and what was lost, because that is the number you are measured on and it is not a number an administrator should be setting for you.

---

## The queue

**Commercial → Enquiries.** Every enquiry in every branch you work in — by email, from the portal, by phone or walk-in. Mail to a mailbox your administrator has connected becomes an enquiry for that branch within a minute, already in the queue and marked unassigned; mail that quotes one of your own references joins that enquiry or job instead of opening a new one.

### What the assistant read off the email

If document extraction is switched on, an emailed enquiry opens with a panel headed **Read from the email**: mode, direction, origin, destination, commodity, Incoterm, cargo-ready date, gross weight, volume, pieces, dimensions and dangerous goods — each as the assistant read it, with the line of the mail it was read from quoted beside it, and the model's confidence.

**Accept** writes the value onto the enquiry, under your own name in the audit trail. **Dismiss** discards it. Nothing touches the enquiry until you decide, and a person's typing always wins: a proposal flagged **Already filled** is one whose field somebody has since typed into, and accepting it is refused rather than overwriting them. A proposal with **No line quoted** has no evidence behind it — read the mail before accepting. Deciding needs the assign permission, so a coordinator can do this too.

Two things matter about an enquiry beyond its content:

**It has an owner.** An enquiry with no owner has nobody's name against the clock. The queue flags unassigned ones. Assign them — to yourself if nobody else — before you do anything else in the morning.

**It has a deadline**, counted in working hours on your branch's calendar. The dashboard shows what has breached and what is due today, and the SLA watch list is ordered by whichever breaches soonest.

The clock stops when a quotation is sent, or when you press **Mark replied**. It does not stop because somebody opened the enquiry, and it does not stop on its own because you replied by email outside the system — which is the most common way a good response time is recorded as a breach. If you did answer outside the system, **Mark replied** records the time of that first reply; it cannot be undone. **Start rating** tells the queue somebody is on it and stops nothing.

---

## Pricing

Open the enquiry and press **Price it**. The system finds a live rate card for the lane, mode and date, calculates chargeable weight for the mode, and applies the accessorials from the catalogue.

### The internal comparison

This is the screen that is worth learning properly. It shows every option with **buy, sell and margin side by side** — before the quotation goes out.

You are seeing the margin at the moment of quoting rather than at month-end. Two consequences worth internalising:

- **A thin margin is a decision, not an accident.** If you send it anyway, you did so knowingly, and that is a defensible answer when somebody asks later.
- **Discounting has a visible floor.** You can see what you are giving away as you give it.

### When there is no rate

You will be told there is no live rate card for the lane rather than given a number that looks plausible. That means nobody has a buying rate on file and whatever you quote is from memory.

**Tell your operations manager rather than working around it.** The rate-card screen has a panel counting exactly these lanes, and yours is a data point that gets a contract negotiated.

---

## The quotation

Sent on your letterhead, in Arabic or English, with your terms and a validity date. **PDF (EN)** and **PDF (AR)** on the quotation page render it; the branch's trading conditions print at the foot and its list of what is not included — duties, taxes, examination charges — prints beside the charges. Both are set per entity by your administrator, because Kuwait and Dubai do not share a footer.

**Send it** moves a draft to *Sent*; the margin is frozen at that moment and a later rate change does not alter it. **Accept** and **Reject** record the customer's answer.

**Revising supersedes.** The previous version is marked superseded and stays readable — so when a customer says "your first price was lower", the first price is still there, exactly as sent. Revise rather than editing, always.

**Validity expires on its own.** A quotation past its validity moves to expired without anyone touching it, which is what stops a customer accepting a March price in September.

## Closing

You close the enquiry, and how you close it is the data. **Close** asks how it ended; **Cancel it** is a separate button, for one that will not be quoted at all.

| CLOSE IT AS | WHEN |
|---|---|
| **Won** | The customer accepted. Accept the quotation too — that is what carries the agreed rates onto the job file, so what was sold is what gets costed. |
| **Lost** | They went elsewhere, or did not proceed. The reason is required — it is the only place this answer gets recorded, and it is what tells you why you lose. |
| **Cancelled** | The cargo does not exist, it was a duplicate, or it was never real. |

**Lost and cancelled are not the same thing and the difference is worth protecting.** Lost means you competed and did not win — that is a win-rate number and a pricing signal. Cancelled means there was nothing to win. A team that cancels its losses has a win rate that looks excellent and means nothing, and the first person misled by it is you.

**Close the lost ones.** An enquiry left open because the answer is disappointing sits in the queue, counts against the branch, and pollutes the response-time median. It costs more to leave it than to close it.

## Customers

You can create and edit customers and their contacts.

**Both names, every time.** English and Arabic. The Arabic name is what appears on the Arabic quotation and in the Arabic portal — a customer record with only an English name produces a document that reads half-finished to the person you are trying to impress.

**A real contact with a real email.** It is what the portal invitation uses, and the portal is the thing that stops them ringing your coordinators.

## What to watch on the dashboard

| | READ IT AS |
|---|---|
| **Median response** | What your customers actually experience, enquiry to quotation. The median rather than the average, because averages hide the bad days. |
| **Win rate** | Quotes won against quotes sent this month. |
| **Average margin** | What you keep on a typical quotation, before overheads. |
| **Enquiries received** | Last fourteen days, against the previous week. |

| | READ IT AS |
|---|---|
| **Busiest lanes** | Where your volume actually is — often not where you think. |

**Read win rate and average margin together, always.** Rising win rate with falling margin means the team is buying work. Falling win rate with rising margin may be exactly right. Either number alone will mislead you, and the dashboard puts them next to each other for that reason.

**Finance → Reports** is the margin report: shipments by the date they sailed, cut by branch, customer, trade lane, mode or salesperson, with revenue, cost, gross profit and margin. **Export CSV** takes it out whole.

---

## Five habits

1. **Nothing stays unassigned overnight.** The clock runs regardless.
2. **Quote in the system, not from your mailbox.** A quotation sent by email outside the system is a breached SLA in the record and an argument you cannot win six months later.
3. **Revise, never edit.** What you sent is evidence.
4. **Close your losses honestly.** Lost is not cancelled.
5. **Report every lane with no rate card.** It is how the contract gets negotiated, and it is your margin next quarter.

# Finance

**Invoicing, receipts and receivables. Yours alone, and deliberately so.**

> Read `00-orientation.md` first.

---

## What you hold, and why nobody else does

| YOURS ALONE | ALSO YOURS |
|---|---|
| Approve an invoice | Record duty paid on a customs declaration |
| **Issue** an invoice | Capture a supplier's bill and match it |
| Void an invoice | Run a set-off with an agent |
| Raise a credit note | Split a consolidation's master cost across its houses |
| Record a receipt | Let a customer trade past their credit limit |
| **Approve** a supplier's bill for payment, and **pay** it | Read every shipment |
| Post the period to the accounting package | Read and export the dashboards and the margin report |

**Only Finance may issue, void or credit.** An operations manager who could issue invoices is the classic separation-of-duties failure, and it is the first one an auditor asks about. It is enforced by the system, not by an instruction — which is the answer you can give when asked. The same line runs through money out: a coordinator or an operations manager can capture what an agent billed, and only you can approve it for payment or pay it.

You **cannot** book or update shipments, change rate cards, or send quotations. If an invoice is wrong because the job is wrong, the job gets fixed by operations and the invoice gets credited by you. Neither of you fixes the other's record.

---

## The receivables screen

**Finance → Overview.** The subtitle is the whole job: *what you are owed, how late it is, and who to ring about it.*

| | WHAT IT MEANS |
|---|---|
| **Owed to you** | Across every open invoice |
| **Overdue** | Past the due date |
| **Received** | What has come in |
| **Unallocated receipts** | **Money in the bank not yet matched to an invoice** |

### Unallocated receipts are the one to clear first

The screen warns about them explicitly, and the reason is worth stating: *until a receipt is matched, the customer still shows as owing money they have already paid.*

Every consequence of that is bad. You chase a customer who has paid. Their credit limit blocks a booking they are entitled to. Your ageing report overstates the debt and your management makes decisions on it.

**Clear them daily.** It is ten minutes and it is the highest-value ten minutes in this chapter.

### Ageing

Everything unpaid, grouped by how late it is: not due yet, 1–30, 31–60, 61–90, over 90. The screen offers a piece of judgement with it — *anything beyond 60 days is usually a phone call, not a reminder* — and it is right.

### Who owes the most

Largest balance first, not oldest. **Chase the biggest exposure before the oldest debt.** A four-month-old invoice for a small amount is an irritation; a six-week-old invoice for a large one is a risk.

Use the ageing view to decide *how* to chase and this view to decide *whom*.

### Earned, not yet billed

Above the ageing, a panel counts the shipments carrying revenue that has never reached an invoice — how many lines, how much, and how old the oldest is. An unbilled charge line never ages, never appears in the ageing and is never chased, which is why it gets its own space.

**Draft invoice** against a row raises a draft for that shipment with its unbilled revenue lines on it, ready to approve and issue. A shipment whose lines are in more than one currency is flagged *Mixed currencies — bill separately*.

---

## Invoicing

### The states, and what each one commits

| STATE | WHAT IT MEANS | REVERSIBLE? |
|---|---|---|
| **Draft** | Being built. No number yet. Charges can be added and changed. | Yes |
| **Approved** | Reviewed and ready. Still no number, still editable. | Yes — back to draft |
| **Issued** | **It takes the next number in the branch's series.** | **No** |
| **Part paid** / **Paid** | Receipts matched against it | — |
| **Void** | Cancelled. The number stays used. | No |
| **Credited** | A credit note replaces it | No |

**Issuing cannot be undone.** The system says so before you do it. An issued invoice can only be corrected by a credit note — and that is the point, because an invoice that can be silently edited after the customer has it is not a document either of you can rely on.

**Voiding keeps the number.** The series has no gap. An invoice series with a missing number is a question at every audit, and the answer *"we deleted it"* is never a good one.

### Building it

Add charges while it is a draft. Each line carries:

- **Description** — what the customer will actually read
- **Charge type** — groups the line on the printed invoice
- **Quantity, unit price**
- **Taxable** — tax is added at this invoice's rate where the line is taxable

Totals recalculate from the lines. There is no total you type over.

### Tax treatment

Set per invoice: **standard rate**, **zero rated**, **exempt**, **out of scope**, **reverse charge**.

This is not decoration — it is what makes an invoice raised by your UAE entity and one raised by your Kuwait entity both correct at the same time. Set it from the entity and the transaction, not from habit.

### Document language

Each invoice carries its own language, English or Arabic. Set it to what the customer wants to receive, not to what you are reading the screen in.

### Currency

Every charge line stores **its own exchange rate and the moment it was taken**. A job quoted in dollars and invoiced in dinars reconciles months later because the rate is recorded rather than recalculated.

**Amounts round per currency at the line.** KWD carries three decimal places and the system knows it. You do not need to correct dinar amounts for rounding, and you should not try.

---

## Receipts

**Finance → Payments.** What came in, and how much of each has been matched.

Record: the date received, the customer, their reference, the method — bank transfer, cheque, cash, card or offset — and the amount.

**Then allocate it.** A receipt can be matched across several invoices, and part of a receipt can sit unallocated if the customer has overpaid or paid on account. The register shows what is matched and what is not, and the overview screen counts the unmatched ones at the top.

**Recorded by** is captured automatically. So is the time. Neither can be changed afterwards.

---

## Duty

You can record duty paid on a customs declaration. So can the customs broker and the operations manager; a coordinator cannot.

The declaration shows the duty assessed. Recording payment moves the declaration forward toward release, and it is usually what somebody is waiting on — a container sitting for a payment nobody recorded is demurrage accruing on your own delay.

---

### Charges that appear without anyone entering them

**Free-time clocks write their own charge lines.** Demurrage, detention and storage accrue against the carrier's free days and post automatically, against the right counterparty at the right per-diem rate.

Two consequences for you:

1. **Do not enter these by hand.** You will duplicate them.
2. **They arrive after delivery.** A job closed the day it was delivered may close before its last accrued charge lands. This is why the operations manager is told to check job costs before closing, and it is worth being the person who reminds them.

---

## Payables

**Finance → Payables.** What suppliers have billed, and where it disagrees with what the job accrued. The subtitle is the job, and the four counters at the top are the order to work in:

| | WHAT IT MEANS |
|---|---|
| **Needs review** | Bills outside tolerance, or matched to nothing. **Start here.** |
| **Awaiting approval** | Captured, not yet released for payment |
| **Overdue** | Past their due date and unpaid |
| **Owed** | Open bills, in base currency |

### Capture, match, approve, pay — and who does which

Four acts, and the split is the separation of duties a forwarder actually runs on:

| ACT | WHO | WHY |
|---|---|---|
| **Capture bill** | Coordinator, operations manager, or you | The coordinator holding the file is the only person who can say which of the thirty shipments on a monthly agent invoice each line belongs to |
| **Match** each line to the job's cost line | The same | Billing more than was accrued is allowed — that is the finding |
| **Approve** for payment | **You alone** | With the variance in front of you. Approving a bill that is 15% over its accrual is a decision somebody has to own |
| **Record payment**, then **Allocate** it | **You alone** | Moving the money |

Collapsing the first two with the third would mean the person who entered the bill is the person who cleared it — the segregation failure an auditor asks about immediately after invoice issuance.

**Read a bill** captures from a scan: upload the PDF or a photograph and the lines are read for you. It lands as *Received*, like anything typed in, and you still approve it. If the figures do not add up, nothing is written and the scan is kept on file. It needs a model key under *Settings → Integrations*.

### Lines and matches

Open a bill. Each of their lines sits beside what it was matched to, with a verdict: **Agrees**, **Within tolerance**, **Billed over**, **Billed under**, **Not billed**. Tolerance comes from the charge type, or from the partner's own tolerance where one has been set on their page — whichever is more generous.

**Approve** is offered when everything agrees. When something does not, the bill says so — *Some lines are outside tolerance, or matched to nothing at all* — and approving means ticking **Approve anyway** and writing why the variance is acceptable. That reason is the record. **Dispute** sends it back with what is wrong; **Void** is only for a bill nothing has been paid against. Their invoice number is captured exactly as printed, and capturing the same number twice is refused.

### Payments not yet placed

At the foot of the payables screen: money that has left the building and is not against a bill — a deposit, an advance, a payment that arrived before its invoice. **Allocate** each one. Part payments are the norm.

---

## Settlements

**Finance → Settlements.** An agent is both a supplier and a customer — they bill you for the far end and you bill them for yours. A settlement nets both sides of the account for a period into a single figure, so one payment moves instead of two.

**Before anything can be netted, the partner must be linked to the customer record they invoice you as** — *Current account* on their partner page. Nothing guesses at which customer record an agent is, because a wrong guess nets a settlement against a different company.

**Draft settlement** — branch, agent, period, and the agreed rate where the two sides are in different currencies. One currency by agreement; a set-off is not a currency trade. The draft lists every open document in the period that no earlier settlement has claimed: your invoices and credit notes, their bills, receipts and payments either way. It shows **They owe us**, **We owe them**, the **Set off**, and the **Residual** with its direction — *They pay us*, *We pay them*, or *Square*.

**Agree statement** when both sides have signed it off. **Residual settled** when the balancing payment has moved. A settlement is never deleted; one that was voided stays on the list with the reason against it.

Running a set-off is yours and the operations manager's. It changes what both sides owe without any money moving, so it sits with whoever answers for the relationship rather than with either ledger.

---

## Credit control

Each customer's page carries **Standing and exceptions**: what they owe, their credit limit, the headroom or the excess, and every override ever made for them. Amounts in a currency with no exchange rate are listed separately, and the exposure shown is a floor rather than a total.

**Booking checks this.** A customer on hold, or one a shipment would take past their limit, cannot be booked, and the coordinator is told so. The answer is **Record an override** — for one shipment, one invoice, or everything for that customer until a date — with a reason a reviewer can act on in a year. The limit itself is set under the customer's commercial terms and stays where it is.

You and the operations manager both hold this, and that is deliberate: a check only one of you can clear is a check that gets routed around at four in the afternoon.

**Unallocated receipts feed straight into this.** A customer who has paid and whose receipt sits unmatched is a customer whose booking is refused for money they do not owe.

## Consolidations

A coordinator builds the master and attaches the houses; **Split** divides each master cost across them, by volume, chargeable weight, gross weight, packages, equally, or stated by hand. It writes an ordinary charge line onto every house, so invoicing and the export need to know nothing about consolidation, and **Reverse** posts the negative rather than deleting, because the lines may already sit on an issued invoice. Splitting is yours and the operations manager's — it decides twenty margins at once.

## Export

**Accounting exports**, on the overview screen, hand a period to your accounting package as a journal — invoices, credit notes, costs and receipts, posted to the accounts mapped on each branch.

| | WHAT IT DOES |
|---|---|
| **Preview journal** | Builds the journal for an entity and a period, and marks nothing. Run it as often as you like. |
| **Post period** | Stamps every invoice, cost and receipt it covers. A second export of the same period finds nothing. |
| **Void** | Releases everything the export claimed, with a reason kept on the record, so the period can be exported again. |

**Post once you are satisfied with the preview.** Posting consumes the period; getting it back is a void with a reason, and *"why was this period posted twice"* is a question the reason has to answer.

**The accounts come from the branch.** *Settings → Branches* carries each entity's chart of accounts — receivables, payables, bank, output tax, FX variance, rounding — and each charge type carries its revenue and cost account under *Reference data*. Leave them blank until you have the codes; the export names what is missing rather than guessing.

**There is no direct connector to an accounting package in this release.** The journal export is the path today.

**Finance → Reports** is the margin report — shipments by the date they sailed, cut by branch, customer, trade lane, mode or salesperson — and **Export CSV** takes it out whole.

## Your week

| WHEN | WHAT |
|---|---|
| **Daily** | Unallocated receipts. Clear every one. |
| **Daily** | New receipts recorded and matched |
| **Daily** | Payables — *Needs review*, then *Awaiting approval* |
| **Weekly** | Overdue — the 61–90 and 90+ buckets, by phone |

| WHEN | WHAT |
|---|---|
| **Weekly** | Who owes the most — largest exposure first |
| **Weekly** | Earned, not yet billed — draft the invoices |
| **Weekly** | Payments not yet placed — allocate every one |
| **On completion** | Invoice the jobs operations has completed |
| **Before closing a job** | Check the free-time charges have landed and the consolidation costs are split |
| **Monthly** | Settlements — draft the set-off for each agent with a current account |
| **Monthly** | Preview the journal, then post the period; reconcile the receipt account |
| **Monthly** | Check the invoice number series has no gaps — voids should keep theirs |

## Four things not to do

**Do not edit an issued invoice by any route.** There is no route, and looking for one means the credit note is the answer.

**Do not delete a receipt to correct it.** Nothing is deleted here. Correct the allocation.

**Do not leave money unallocated over a weekend.** Everything downstream of it is wrong until you do, including how your colleagues treat that customer.

**Do not close the month with unmatched receipts on the register.** The ageing report is wrong by exactly that amount, and somebody will act on it.

# Customs Broker

**A narrow role, on purpose. Declarations, and the shipment fields clearance depends on.**

> Read `00-orientation.md` first.

---

## What you hold

| YOU CAN | YOU CANNOT |
|---|---|
| File and update a customs declaration | Create or book a shipment |
| Record duty paid | Cancel, complete or close one |
| Update shipments — dates, references, containers | Price an enquiry or send a quotation |
| Read every shipment in your branches | Add a rate card, agent or port |
| | Touch an invoice or a receipt |

The role is deliberately narrow. You need the declaration and the shipment fields clearance depends on, and nothing else — which also means nothing else can go wrong under your account.

---

## The customs screen

**Operations → Customs.** Declarations in clearance, **ordered by the window that closes first**.

That ordering is the feature. It is not newest-first and it is not by shipment reference: it is by which clearance deadline expires soonest, so the top of the list is where the next problem is.

Each row shows the shipment, the customer, the declaration number, when it was filed, when clearance is due, the broker, and the duty.

The counters at the top: **in clearance**, **held**, **released**, **inspection required**. Held and inspection are the two that mean somebody must do something today.

---

## The declaration, stage by stage

| STAGE | WHAT IT MEANS | WHAT MOVES IT ON |
|---|---|---|
| **Not started** | Nothing filed | Documents arrive |
| **Waiting for documents** | The file is short something | The missing document |
| **Declaration filed** | Lodged with the authority | Assessment, or an inspection order |
| **Assessed** | Duty determined | Payment — recorded by you, Finance or the operations manager |
| **Duty paid** | Settled | Release, or an inspection |

| STAGE | WHAT IT MEANS | WHAT MOVES IT ON |
|---|---|---|
| **Inspection** | Physical examination ordered | Release, or a hold |
| **Held** | Held by the authority | Re-inspection, or release |
| **Released** | Cleared to move | — |

**A declaration can be held from waiting-for-documents as well.** A file short of a certificate long enough becomes a hold, and it looks exactly like a hold caused by the authority. The way to prevent it is to record the missing document as an exception on the shipment the day you notice it, not the day it becomes a hold.

**Record the declaration number as soon as you have it.** It is what everyone else in the office uses to ask the authority anything, and it is what makes the clearance auditable afterwards.

All of this is one dialog on the shipment — **Update customs**: the stage, the broker, the declaration type and number, the duty payable as assessed, the clear-by date the register sorts on, whether a physical inspection is required, and notes. Only the stages customs can actually move to next are accepted.

### Before it is filed

**Estimate duty**, on the shipment, gives a landed cost before anything is lodged: goods value, freight and insurance against the tariff loaded under *Reference data → Tariff*, matched by the HS code on each cargo line, longest prefix first. It is an estimate, not an assessment — the screen says so — and both are kept, so the gap between them can be measured. Lines with no HS code are left out unless you choose to apply the GCC general rate to them, which is off by default because 5% on a code the tariff has no row for is a guess that looks researched.

The **Customs declaration pack** is one of the documents the shipment can issue from its bill parties and cargo lines — what you would otherwise retype into the authority's system. Preview it in either language from **Issue and preview**; issuing it is the coordinator's.

---

## Free time is running while you are working

Every day a container sits in clearance is a day against its free time. Demurrage, detention and storage clocks run against the carrier's free days and **write their own charge lines** when the free days run out.

Nobody has to notice, which cuts both ways: nobody has to notice, and nobody does. The dashboard shows the total accruing across the branch, and the shipment shows free days, chargeable days and the per-diem rate.

**The dates that stop clocks are yours to enter promptly.** Each clock under *Free time* on the shipment has a start and an **Ends** date, and the end date is what stops the accrual — charged days stay:

| THE BOX | STOPS | IF YOU LEAVE IT LATE |
|---|---|---|
| **Gated out** of the terminal | Demurrage | The charge keeps accruing on paper after the box has left |
| **Empty returned** to the line | Detention | A detention clock that never stops — a wrong charge, and an argument with the customer you will lose |

Enter them on the day. Not at the end of the week.

---

## Exceptions

When clearance goes wrong — a hold, an inspection, a document that has not come, a discrepancy in the declared value — **raise an exception on the shipment**.

Give it a severity, an owner and a due date, and the cost impact if there is one. It appears on the operations board, oldest first, and it is how the rest of the office finds out without you telling each of them separately.

**Raise it even when you expect to resolve it today.** How often a lane, an agent or a commodity produces a hold is a pattern worth having, and it only exists if the short-lived ones were recorded too.

---

## What this system does not do

**It does not file declarations.** You file where you file today — the authority's own system, your broker portal, an agent. This system records the declaration, its number, its status, the duty and the deadline, so that everyone else can see where clearance has got to without ringing you.

For Kuwait specifically, direct filing is **not planned**. Access runs through a long-standing concession that a supplier of this software has no route into, and that is the honest position rather than a roadmap item.

**It does not assess duty.** It estimates it, from the tariff your operations manager loads; what the authority determines on filing is what you record, and the two are kept side by side.

**It does not receive authority status feeds.** Every customs status change is entered by a person — you. Carrier milestone feeds are a different matter: your administrator can switch on carrier-direct tracking for Maersk, Hapag-Lloyd and CMA CGM under *Settings → Integrations*, with each carrier's own registration. Until that is done, vessel milestones are typed too.

---

## Your day

| WHEN | WHAT |
|---|---|
| **First thing** | The customs screen. It is already ordered by which deadline closes first. |
| **First thing** | Held and inspection counters — these need action today |
| **On the day it happens** | Gated out, empty returned |
| **On the day you get it** | Declaration number, duty assessed, release |
| **As soon as you notice** | An exception for every hold, inspection or missing document |
| **Weekly** | Arriving this week, on the dashboard — clearance you can prepare before it lands |

# Administrator

**You own the deployment. This chapter is what only you can do, and the four things that will hurt if you do them carelessly.**

> Read `00-orientation.md` first. You hold every permission in the system, including any added by a future release — so every other chapter in this manual also describes something you can do.

---

## Settings

**Settings** sits apart from the operations navigation and has its own shell. The reason is stated in the product: *nothing here moves a shipment.* These screens configure the operator — who may sign in, what a branch invoices as, what the product is called.

| SCREEN | WHAT IT IS FOR |
|---|---|
| **Users & roles** | Who can sign in, and what they hold in each branch |
| **Branches** | Currency, invoice series, working calendar, trading conditions, chart of accounts, per entity |
| **Audit log** | Every write, by whom, from where |
| **Vendor access** | What your supplier's support can see, and for how long |
| **Notification wording** | What the product says when it writes to somebody — shared with the operations manager, see `02-operations-manager.md` |
| **API keys** | Read-only keys a customer's systems pull their shipments with, and the webhooks that push events to them |
| **Mailboxes** | The addresses the system reads for incoming enquiries, per branch |
| **Integrations** | The relay that sends the mail, the carrier registrations, the file store, the model key, and the provider that will transmit invoices |
| **Brand** | Colours, name and mark, and the variable behind each |

They appear in that order, and `/settings` opens on the first one your role can see.

**Reference data deliberately stayed in operations.** Ports, charge types, milestone templates and exception codes are daily operational work, and putting them behind an administrative wall is how a system grows a free-text "Other" field that swallows the data it was meant to structure. Your operations manager owns them — see `02-operations-manager.md`.

---

## Users and roles

### Adding someone

**The product is invitation-only. There is no sign-up form**, so there is nothing to bootstrap from and nothing for a stranger to find.

**Settings → Users & roles** lists everyone: name, email, their branch and role badges, whether they have a sign-in, when they were last seen, and whether they are active. **Invite someone** creates a person — both names, email, phone, language, role, and the branches they work in, ticked one by one. You can only grant branches you hold yourself; `admin.users.write` in one branch is not a route to every branch.

**The dialog deliberately has no password field**, and it does not create a sign-in. An administrator who can type a colleague's password can sign in as them, and the audit log would say it was the colleague. The credential is created from a shell on the server, against the same email, and the two rows are linked:

```
pnpm db:create-user --email ops@yourcompany.com --name "Operations" \
                    --role operations_manager
```

That writes, in one transaction, the four rows an account needs: the auth user, the hashed credential, the domain principal, and **a role per branch**. Without the branch role the account signs in and sees nothing — which is the most common way a new user's first day goes wrong.

By default it grants the role in every active branch. To scope it to one:

```
pnpm db:create-user --email kwi@yourcompany.com --name "Kuwait Desk" \
                    --role coordinator --branch KWI
```

The generated password prints once. Give it to the person directly. Do not email it.

### Suspending someone

**Suspend**, on their row. It takes their access away on their next request; everything they wrote stays exactly as it is, and their name keeps appearing on the records they created. Nothing is deleted — the account stays on the list, marked inactive, and **Restore** gives it back with the same branches and roles.

### Resetting a password

Two paths. **Forgotten your password?** on the sign-in page sends the person a link that expires in an hour — it needs *Outbound mail* configured under **Settings → Integrations**, and a deployment without it logs the failure rather than appearing to work. Or re-run `db:create-user` for the existing email: it resets that password and changes nothing else, and it is the path when mail is not yet configured.

### Roles are per branch

The same person can be a **coordinator in Kuwait and read-only in Dubai**. That is the intended shape, not a workaround — a person who covers another office during a holiday gets read access there and keeps their own role at home.

Every screen counts and shows only the branches a person holds a role in. There is no "all branches" toggle, and there should not be.

### Two-factor

**Administrator and Finance must enrol.** They are the two roles that can change who has access and can issue money documents. Nobody can opt out, including you. The requirement is a flag on the role, not on the person: the **Roles** table on this screen shows *Two-factor: Required* against those two, with the number of permissions each role holds, and a person's badge carries the same mark.

### Choosing a role

Seven roles, described in full in `09-permissions-reference.md`. Three rules of thumb:

**Grant the narrowest role that lets someone do their job.** The customs broker role exists precisely so that a broker does not need a coordinator's access.

**Do not put an operations person in the Finance role because they "help with invoices".** The separation between issuing invoices and running operations is the one an auditor asks about first, and it is enforced rather than advised.

**Read-only is a real answer.** For an owner who wants to look, a new joiner in their first fortnight, or an accountant who needs to see and not touch.

---

## Branches

Each branch carries **its own base currency, its own invoice series and its own working calendar**. **Add branch** and **Edit branch** on **Settings → Branches**:

| | WHY IT MATTERS |
|---|---|
| **Code** | Short, and it prefixes every reference this branch creates |
| **Currency** | What the entity reports and invoices in |
| **Legal name**, in both languages | The Arabic one is required — it appears on Arabic invoices |
| **Invoice prefix** | Numbering is per branch, and gaps are questions at audit. Voided invoices keep their number for exactly this reason. Defaults to the branch code, and **cannot be changed once invoices have been issued**. |
| **House B/L series** | Numbers the house bills the branch issues. Leave blank to number them by hand. |
| **Working calendar** | **Every SLA clock and ageing rule counts against this.** Kuwait, Qatar and the UAE share neither a weekend nor a holiday list. |
| **Time zone**, **tax registration** | Per entity — `Asia/Kuwait` and `Asia/Dubai` are not the same hour |
| **Trading conditions** and **Not included** | Printed at the foot of, and beside the charges on, every quotation this entity issues — in both languages. Each entity trades under its own law; Kuwait and Dubai do not share a footer. |
| **Sends from** | Who notifications from this entity come from. Blank uses the deployment's own address. |
| **Quiet hours** | No customer notification leaves between these hours, in the branch's local time. Internal alerts are never held. |
| **Chart of accounts** | Receivables, payables, bank, output tax, FX variance, rounding — where this entity posts. Leave blank until you have the codes; the accounting export names what is missing. |

**Load next year's public holidays before January.** If you do not, every deadline over the break is wrong, in the same direction, for every branch — and nobody notices until a customer does.

---

## The audit log

Every write, recorded **by the database itself** rather than by the application — so a change that goes around the application is still recorded. When, what operation, which table, who, which branch, which record, from which address.

**Nobody can edit or delete an entry.** Update and delete are revoked from every role in the system, including yours and including your supplier's. This is not a policy; it is a permission that does not exist.

Read it when a figure is disputed or a change needs attributing. That is what it is for, and it is worth telling your team it exists — not as a threat, but because a team that knows changes are attributable argues less about what happened.

---

## Vendor access — the one to understand properly

**Support cannot see your data by default.** There is no standing access, no support account with a permanent key, and no back door.

When your supplier needs to look at something, **you grant it**, from **Settings → Vendor access**:

| FIELD | WHAT TO PUT |
|---|---|
| **Engineer** | The named person. Not a team. |
| **Ticket or reason** | e.g. `SUP-1042 — invoice total disputed on KWI-2026-01041`. Recorded against every session opened under the grant. |
| **Expires after** | A number of hours. Choose the smallest that is plausible. |
| **Access** | Read only, or read and write |
| **Branches** | Leave blank for the branches you hold. **Choosing fewer is always safer.** |

**Read-and-write requires typing `GRANT WRITE` to confirm.** The friction is deliberate. Most support work is diagnosis and needs read access only — ask what they intend to change before you grant write, and if the answer is "nothing yet", grant read.

While a grant is live, **a banner sits at the top of every page** of your system saying so, for everyone. Nobody is unaware that an outsider is in.

You can **revoke it in one click**, at any time, without explanation.

Every grant and every session opened under it is recorded permanently, and *that record cannot be edited or deleted by anyone, including your supplier*. So the question "what did they look at" always has an answer.

**Habits worth keeping:**

- Grant hours, not days
- Grant read unless write has been justified in words you understood
- Grant the branch in question, not all of them
- Revoke when the call ends rather than waiting for expiry
- Read the vendor-access screen once a month even when nothing is open

---

## Mailboxes

**Settings → Mailboxes.** The addresses this system reads. Mail arriving in one becomes an enquiry for that branch, or joins the thread of the enquiry or job it quotes by reference. The service checks every connected mailbox once a minute, and a new enquiry is on the board within that.

**Connect a mailbox**: the branch whose enquiries arrive there, the address, the IMAP server and port, TLS, the password, the folder (usually `INBOX`), and optionally a folder to move handled mail to — leave it blank and mail is marked read where it is. The password is stored encrypted and is never shown again; when editing, leave it blank to keep the one stored.

**This is your key, not the operations manager's**, and the reason is stated in the matrix: a charge type is a business rule, and this row is the password to a mailbox that in an office this size is usually somebody's whole account.

Each row shows when it was last checked and when mail last arrived. A mailbox marked **Not reading** collects no enquiries — check the password first, because most failures here are a credential that changed. **Stop reading** pauses one without losing anything; **Start reading** resumes, and anything unread that accumulated in the meantime arrives as enquiries.

**Before connecting a real mailbox:** the deployment needs `MAILBOX_ENCRYPTION_KEY` set, or the form cannot be saved — it says so. And you hold no branch you cannot connect a mailbox for; an administrator with no branch role is told to get one first.

---

## Integrations

**Settings → Integrations.** The accounts this deployment reaches the outside world with. A credential saved here takes effect within a minute, with no release, and takes precedence over the deployment's environment variables — **Stop using these settings** falls back to the environment without losing what was typed, which is how a change is rolled back.

Credentials are sealed on the way in and never shown again; leave a field blank to keep the one stored. The first option in each mode list is the one that costs nothing and asks nobody.

| GROUP | CARD | WHAT IT DOES |
|---|---|---|
| **Platform** | **Outbound mail** | The relay every notification leaves through. Without it nothing reaches a customer and nobody can be sent a password reset. *Sending*, or *Written to the log, not sent*. |
| | **Object storage** | Where every stored document lives — issued bills, invoices, scans. Without it documents render but cannot be kept. |
| | **Inbound mail webhook** | The shared secret a mail provider signs its forwarding webhook with. Separate from the mailboxes above. |
| **Carriers** | **Container tracking** | *Typed by an operator*, or *Carrier-direct (free)*. The driver only; the credentials live on the three carrier cards. |
| | **Maersk**, **Hapag-Lloyd**, **CMA CGM** | One self-serve registration each, at the carrier's own developer portal. Each card says which carrier codes it covers and what is still needed before it can be switched on. |

| GROUP | CARD | WHAT IT DOES |
|---|---|---|
| | **Carrier poll budget** | How often the poll asks and how many shipments each run covers. The card works out calls per hour, which has to stay under the carrier's cap. |
| **Finance** | **Exchange rates** | *Typed by hand*, or *Daily from a feed*. Nothing prices from the feed — a charge line keeps the rate it was struck at. |
| | **E-invoice transmission** | The accredited provider that files an invoice with the tax authority. *Not transmitted* until somebody has bought one. |
| **Document extraction** | **Document extraction** | The model key. It switches on the assistant, reading enquiries off emails, and reading supplier bills from scans — billed per document, with a monthly ceiling set here. An unread bill is simply one that gets typed. |

A card marked **Not working** is one the service could not resolve on its last run; the reason is on the card, and correcting it here takes effect within a minute.

**Carrier tracking is built but off until you register.** With the driver on *Carrier-direct* and a carrier's credentials entered, container milestones on that carrier's shipments arrive from the carrier's own events. Until then, every milestone is typed — and a WhatsApp Business card on this screen notwithstanding, WhatsApp is not a channel in this release.

---

## API keys

**Settings → API keys.** Read-only keys a customer's own systems use to pull their shipments, milestones and released documents from the read API, without a login.

**Issue a key** — a name (*their ERP, their portal…*), the customer it reads for, the branch, and an optional expiry. **The key is shown once and is not stored.** If it is lost, revoke it and issue another. Each row shows when it was last used; **Revoke** ends it, and keys are revoked, never deleted, so *when did it stop working* always has an answer.

**Webhooks** are the other direction: where the system posts an event the moment it happens, so a customer's system does not have to poll. **Subscribe** with an `https` URL and, optionally, the events wanted — empty means everything. Each delivery is signed with HMAC-SHA256 in `x-qabandi-signature` using a secret shown once at subscription; give it to whoever receives the events, because they verify the signature with it. Each endpoint shows its last delivery and how many are failing, and can be turned off without being removed.

---

## Brand

**Settings → Brand** shows every colour, name and mark the product resolves at runtime — and the environment variable behind each one.

The whole product is re-skinned by setting variables. No rebuild, no code change:

```
BRAND_NAME_EN="Meridian Logistics" BRAND_MONOGRAM=M \
BRAND_PRIMARY_HUE=155 BRAND_ACCENT_HUE=25 BRAND_RADIUS=4
```

Both themes, every tonal ramp, every semantic colour and the chart series derive from those tokens. The screen renders the resolved values so the claim is inspectable rather than asserted.

**Two things deliberately do not follow your brand, and should not be made to:**

**Status colours.** Positive, caution, critical, info and muted are reserved for state. A board where "held" is calm because it matched a corporate palette is worse than useless. If your brand hue lands within about 15° of one of them, it will read as that status — move the brand hue, not the status colour.

**Chart series.** Four slots, assigned in order and never cycled. All four are validated for lightness, contrast against both surfaces, and separation under the two common forms of colour blindness, in both light and dark themes. Changing one means re-running that validation.

---

## Bulk import

**Network → Bulk import.** Bringing existing data in from a spreadsheet, checked row by row before anything is written.

### What can be imported

| | NOTES |
|---|---|
| **Customers** | Both names, code, terms |
| **Customer contacts** | Attached to customers by code |
| **Agents and hauliers** | The partner register |
| **Ports and places** | |
| **Rate cards** | Buy — an agent tariff, needs the partner — or sell |
| **Open jobs** | For a mid-year cutover |
| **Open receivables** | For a mid-year cutover |

### How it works

1. **Choose what to import**, and the branch. Every row is created against that branch.
2. **Download the template** if you want the columns in the right order.
3. **Choose the file.** CSV or tab-separated, saved from Excel. The first row must be the headings.
4. **Check the file.** Columns are matched to your headings automatically; correct anything your agent named differently. Unmatched columns are listed as ignored so nothing is silently dropped.
5. **Read the result.** Rows read, rows accepted, and every problem with its line number. You can download the problem list.
6. **Import**, only if everything passed.

### The rule that matters

**A file with any errors imports nothing.** Not the good rows — nothing.

That is deliberate and it is worth defending when somebody asks for a partial-import option. A half-imported customer list is worse than no import, because nobody can tell which half is in, and the second attempt creates duplicates of the first.

**Rate cards will be rejected for overlapping an existing card on the same lane.** That is the protection working — two overlapping cards on one lane are unrepresentable in this system, by design. Fix the validity dates on one of them.

### Doing a real migration

**Order matters**, because later files refer to earlier ones:

1. Ports and places
2. Agents and hauliers
3. Customers
4. Customer contacts
5. Rate cards — sell first, then buy per partner
6. Open jobs
7. Open receivables

**Import into one branch first and look at the result** before running the rest. Ten minutes of checking here saves a day of unpicking, and there is no undo — the correction path is editing records, not re-running the file.

---

## Operating the deployment

If your supplier operates the deployment, this section is theirs. If you operate it yourself, this is the whole of the job.

| COMMAND | WHAT IT DOES |
|---|---|
| `pnpm db:migrate` | Apply schema migrations. Forward-only. |
| `pnpm db:seed` | Reference rows and the role/permission matrix |
| `pnpm db:create-user` | Provision an account that can sign in |
| `pnpm fleet:status` | What schema version each deployment is on, and whether it is reachable |
| `pnpm fleet:migrate` | Migrate across deployments, sequentially, with a report |
| `pnpm fleet:backup` | Dump every deployment |
| `pnpm fleet:restore-drill` | Dump, restore into a scratch database, verify, drop |

**`fleet:restore-drill` is the one to schedule.** A backup nobody has restored is a hypothesis. The drill restores into a scratch database and checks the *content*, not the exit status — including that the security policies survived, because a restore that drops them produces a database that looks perfect and enforces nothing.

**Dumps must be taken through the admin connection.** The application account cannot read outside its own branches, so a dump taken as the application role is silently partial — the most dangerous artefact in this whole area, because it looks like a backup.

---

## What only you can break

**Granting the wrong role.** Every other mistake in this manual is recoverable from the audit log. This one is somebody seeing what they should not, and it is not visible until it matters. Grant the narrowest role.

**Granting standing vendor write access.** Hours, not days. Read, not write, unless justified.

**Forgetting the working calendar.** Every SLA in the system counts against it. A missing holiday list is every deadline wrong in the same direction, silently.

**An unverified backup.** Run the restore drill on a schedule. Do not assume the dump is good because the command exited zero.

---

## What is not in this release

| | |
|---|---|
| **A sign-in created from a screen** | *Invite someone* creates the person and their branch roles; the credential is still created from a shell, against the same email. |
| **Self-service password reset without mail** | *Forgotten your password?* works once *Outbound mail* is configured. Until then, `db:create-user` is the reset path. |
| **Editing the role matrix from the interface** | The matrix is seeded and editable without a release, but not from a screen today. The *Roles* table on Users & roles shows it. |
| **WhatsApp notifications** | Not in this release. Email is the channel, once *Outbound mail* is configured. |
| **Carrier tracking without registering** | The feeds are carrier-direct and need each carrier's own credentials under *Integrations*. Until they are entered, milestones are typed. |
| **Scheduled reports** | In delivery. Every screen exports today. |

# Tracking your shipments

> **To the operator, before you send this:** this chapter is written to be handed to your customers under your own name. It contains no supplier branding and names no software. Replace `[Company]` with your company name, `[track URL]` with your tracking address, `[portal URL]` with your portal address, and `[phone]` / `[email]` with your operations contacts. Then delete this box.
>
> It has an Arabic counterpart. Send the one your customer reads.

---

There are two ways to see where your cargo is. Neither of them is ringing us, though you are always welcome to.

| | FOR | NEEDS AN ACCOUNT |
|---|---|---|
| **Track a shipment** | A quick check on one shipment | No |
| **The portal** | Everything we are moving for you, at a glance | Yes |

---

## Tracking one shipment — no account

Go to **[track URL]**.

You need two things, both of which are on your booking confirmation:

1. **The shipment reference** — for example `KWI-2026-01041`
2. **A container number, booking number or bill of lading number** from that shipment

Two identifiers rather than one, because a shipment reference on its own could be guessed. Requiring something only you and we would know keeps your shipment details yours.

### What you will see

| | |
|---|---|
| **Progress** | Each step of the journey, and how many are complete |
| **Route** | Where it is going from and to, and how it is travelling |
| **Vessel or flight** | What it is travelling on, and when it departed |
| **Estimated arrival** | And the actual arrival once it lands |
| **Notices** | Anything we have flagged on the shipment for you to know about |
| **Containers** | Numbers and types |
| **Documents** | Those we have released to you, listed by name and size. Ask us and we will send them over. |

Steps are marked **completed**, **in progress**, **scheduled** or **revised**. *Revised* means a date has changed since the original plan — usually a vessel schedule — and it stays visible rather than quietly replacing what we told you before.

### Arabic and English

The language switch is at the top of the page. It changes everything, including the direction the page reads.

### On your phone

The page is built for it. Bookmark it. Your reference is on your booking confirmation and does not change for the life of the shipment.

### If nothing is found

Check both values against your booking confirmation — the second identifier must belong to that same shipment. If it still does not work, ring us on **[phone]** or email **[email]** and we will look.

---

## The portal — for your account

**[portal URL]**, with the sign-in we have set up for you. Ask us if you do not have one.

### What is there

**My shipments.** Everything we are moving for you, with three counts at the top — active shipments, arriving this week, documents released — and a card for each shipment: the reference, where it stands, the route and how it is travelling, your own reference if you gave us one, the estimated arrival, the next step, and how far through its journey it is.

**For the full detail on one shipment** — each step with its dates, the containers, the documents by name — use the tracking page with that shipment's reference and a container or bill number. The portal is the overview; the tracking page is the close-up.

**Documents.** Each shipment shows how many documents we have released to you, and the tracking page lists them by name. Ask us and we will send them over.

### About documents

**You see what we have released, not everything that exists.** A document being prepared, or one waiting on a correction, is not shown until it is final. This is so that you never work from a draft.

If you expected a document and it is not there, ring us — it usually means it is still in preparation, and we would rather tell you that than send you something we are about to change.

**A released document that is later corrected keeps both versions.** You will see the current one; the earlier one is not deleted, so if we ever need to agree what was issued and when, the answer exists.

---

## Which one to use

**Tracking** is for the question *"where is it?"* — quick, no account, works on a phone, and you can forward the link to your own customer with the two identifiers.

**The portal** is for *"what is happening across everything of ours?"*

---

## Questions we get asked

**Can I see shipments that are finished?** The portal lists your shipments in order of arrival, completed ones included, up to fifty at a time; the count at the top is the active ones. Ask us for anything beyond that and we will send it.

**Can more than one person in my company have access?** Yes. Tell us who, and we will set them up.

**Why do I need two identifiers to track?** So that nobody who happens to guess a reference number can see your shipment details. It is your protection, not our bureaucracy.

**The estimated arrival changed.** Vessel and flight schedules move. When ours changes, the page shows it as *revised* rather than pretending the original date never existed. If a change affects you, we will normally have rung you before you see it.

**Something looks wrong.** Ring **[phone]** or email **[email]** with the shipment reference. The reference is what makes it findable in seconds.

---

**[Company] · [phone] · [email]**

# Agents and partners

> **Read this before you promise anything to an agent.** The agent portal is a scaffold in this release, not a working portal. This chapter says exactly what exists today, how to work with your agent network in the meantime, and what the portal will be when it ships.

---

## What exists today

**The route exists and is correctly scoped.** An agent contact who signs in sees only jobs where their own partner record is named on the shipment — and that scoping is enforced by the database, as one arm of the same policy that separates your branches. It is not an application that was bolted on and then filtered.

**The screen itself is a placeholder.** It says *"Assigned shipments — shipments where you are named as a partner, and open rate requests"* and shows nothing else. RFQ dispatch, agents responding to rate requests, agents posting milestones and documents, and compliance self-service are **in delivery**, not shipped.

**So: do not give an agent a login yet.** An agent who signs in and finds an empty screen has learned something about you that is hard to unlearn. Wait until it ships.

The reason it was left this way rather than mocked up is worth knowing, because it is the same reason the rest of this manual is blunt about gaps: a portal that requires real agents to log in and respond cannot be demonstrated convincingly with fake data, so it was scoped correctly and left honest rather than filled in.

---

## How to work with agents today

Everything below is live, and it is the part that carries the operational weight.

### The partner register

**Network → Partners & agents.** Agents, hauliers and carriers, with their contacts (*People there*), the lanes they cover (*Where they go*), their papers, and their account with you.

Keep three things true:

**Both names.** English and Arabic — they appear on documents.

**The lanes they cover.** A partner with no lanes recorded is never suggested for a quote.

**Compliance documents and their expiry dates.** Trade licence, insurance, whatever your jurisdiction requires. **An expiry date that is not maintained is worse than no register**, because it produces confidence that is not warranted, and the moment it surfaces is during an audit rather than during a job.

Until the compliance expiry reminders ship, this needs a diary entry: review the register monthly and chase what expires in the next sixty days.

### Naming an agent on a shipment

**Engage a partner** on the shipment — the role they play and their own reference. That is what makes the job visible to their contacts when the portal ships — and today it is what makes your own operations board show who is handling the other end, and what a supplier's bill is matched against.

Do it at booking, not at the point something goes wrong. A shipment with no partner named is one where the answer to *"who is our agent at destination?"* lives in somebody's memory.

### Agent tariffs

An agent's rates go in as a **buy** rate card belonging to that partner. Load them once and every quotation on those lanes prices from a contract rather than from a search of somebody's mailbox.

A spreadsheet from an agent goes through **Network → Bulk import** — choose *Rate cards*, direction *Buy*, and the partner it belongs to. Every line is checked before anything is written, and if one line fails, nothing is imported.

**A card will be rejected for overlapping an existing card on the same lane.** That is the protection working: two overlapping cards on one lane cannot exist in this system. Fix the validity dates on one of them.

### Rate requests, in the meantime

Send them the way you send them today — email, WhatsApp, the phone. When the answer comes back, put it in as a buy rate card with the validity the agent quoted. That way the next quotation on that lane prices itself, and the request does not have to be repeated in six weeks.

### The agent's bills, and the account between you

When an agent bills you, the coordinator holding the file captures it under **Finance → Payables** — or reads it from the scan — and matches each line to the cost on the job. Finance approves it with the variance in front of them, and pays it.

Where the same agent also pays you, link them on their partner page to the customer record they invoice you as — *Current account* — and **Finance → Settlements** nets both sides of the period into one figure. See `04-finance.md`.

### Milestones and documents from the far end

Your coordinator enters them. When an agent emails a milestone date or a document, it gets entered against the shipment the same day — see `01-coordinator.md`. Mail that quotes your own shipment reference joins that shipment's thread on arrival, if the mailbox it reached is one your administrator has connected.

**The same day, not the same week.** Your customer's tracking page is only as current as the last date somebody entered, and an agent's update sitting in a mailbox is a customer ringing you to ask a question the system could have answered.

---

## What the portal will be

When it ships, an agent contact will sign in and see:

| | |
|---|---|
| **Assigned shipments** | Jobs where their partner is named — already scoped correctly today |
| **Rate requests** | RFQs you have sent them, with responses coming back into your comparison |
| **Rate-card upload** | Their tariff, loaded by them, checked the same way your imports are |
| **Milestone and document posting** | The far end updating the shipment directly |
| **Compliance self-service** | Their own licences and expiry dates, maintained by them |

The last one is the quiet win: the compliance register stops being something you chase and becomes something they maintain.

**Ask your supplier which release**, and get the answer in writing. If you are being told "soon", ask again.

---

## What to tell an agent who asks

> "We have a portal coming where you will see your assigned shipments, respond to rate requests and post milestones directly. It is not open yet and we will tell you when it is. Until then, nothing changes at your end — send us what you send us today."

Do not promise a date you were not given in writing.

# Who can do what

**The permission matrix, exactly as shipped.** Written for whoever asks — a new administrator deciding which role to grant, or an auditor asking how separation of duties is enforced.

> This is the seeded matrix. It is editable without a software release, so if your deployment has been changed, this page describes the starting point rather than your current state. Your administrator can confirm.

## The seven roles in one line each

| ROLE | IN ONE LINE | TWO-FACTOR |
|---|---|---|
| **Administrator** | Everything, including anything a future release adds | **Required** |
| **Finance** | Invoicing, receipts, duty payment. Nothing operational. | **Required** |
| **Operations Manager** | Everything a coordinator does, plus the reversals, rate cards and reference data | No |
| **Coordinator** | Moves shipments forward. Cannot reverse them. | No |
| **Sales** | Enquiry to award. Nothing operational, nothing financial. | No |
| **Customs Broker** | Declarations, and the shipment fields clearance depends on | No |
| **Read Only** | Sees shipments and reports. Changes nothing. | No |

**Administrator is not a listed set of permissions.** It receives every key, including keys added by future releases — so a new capability cannot ship unreachable. That is why it is not a role to hand out freely.

## The full matrix

● held · ○ not held

| PERMISSION | WHAT IT ALLOWS | ADMIN | FIN | OPS MGR | COORD | SALES | CUSTOMS | READ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| `enquiry.assign` | Give an enquiry an owner | ● | ○ | ● | ● | ● | ○ | ○ |
| `enquiry.rate` | Price an enquiry | ● | ○ | ● | ● | ● | ○ | ○ |
| `enquiry.close` | Close won or lost | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ○ |
| `enquiry.cancel` | Cancel an enquiry | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ○ |
| `quote.send` | Send a quotation | ● | ○ | ● | ● | ● | ○ | ○ |
| `quote.revise` | Supersede with a new version | ● | ○ | ● | ● | ● | ○ | ○ |

| PERMISSION | WHAT IT ALLOWS | ADMIN | FIN | OPS MGR | COORD | SALES | CUSTOMS | READ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| `quote.accept` | Record acceptance | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ○ |
| `quote.reject` | Record rejection | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ○ |
| `job.read` | See shipments | ● | ● | ● | ● | ● | ● | ● |
| `job.book` | Move a shipment out of draft | ● | ○ | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `job.update` | Milestones, dates, references | ● | ○ | ● | ● | ○ | ● | ○ |
| `job.hold` | Place on hold and release | ● | ○ | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `job.complete` | Mark operationally finished | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `job.close` | Close financially | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `job.cancel` | Cancel a shipment | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `customs.file` | Record a declaration | ● | ○ | ● | ● | ○ | ● | ○ |
| `customs.update` | Move it through its stages | ● | ○ | ● | ● | ○ | ● | ○ |
| `customs.pay` | Record duty paid | ● | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ● | ○ |
| `document.generate` | Issue a generated document — house bill, delivery order, packing list, customs pack | ● | ○ | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `document.release` | Release a document to the customer | ● | ○ | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `consol.write` | Build a consolidation and attach houses | ● | ○ | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `consol.allocate` | Split the master cost across the houses | ● | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `invoice.approve` | Mark reviewed | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `invoice.issue` | **Allocate the number. Irreversible.** | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `invoice.void` | Cancel; the number stays used | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |

| PERMISSION | WHAT IT ALLOWS | ADMIN | FIN | OPS MGR | COORD | SALES | CUSTOMS | READ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| `invoice.credit` | Raise a credit note | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `payment.record` | Record and allocate a receipt | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `finance.export` | Export financial data | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `credit.override` | Let a shipment book past a credit hold, with a reason | ● | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `payable.record` | Capture a supplier bill | ● | ● | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `payable.approve` | Approve a matched bill for payment | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `payable.pay` | Record a supplier payment | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `settlement.run` | Run and agree a partner settlement | ● | ● | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `rate.card.write` | Create or change a rate card | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `customer.write` | Create or edit customers | ● | ○ | ● | ● | ● | ○ | ○ |
| `partner.write` | Agents, hauliers, carriers | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `report.read` | Dashboards and exports | ● | ● | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ● |
| `admin.reference.write` | Ports, charge types, milestones, calendars | ● | ○ | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `admin.users.write` | Users, roles, **and vendor access** | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `admin.branches.write` | Branch configuration | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `admin.audit.read` | The audit log | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `admin.brand.read` | Branding tokens | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `admin.api_keys.write` | API keys for the read API and webhooks | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |

| PERMISSION | WHAT IT ALLOWS | ADMIN | FIN | OPS MGR | COORD | SALES | CUSTOMS | READ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| `admin.integrations.write` | Storage, mail, FX, carrier, model and e-invoice settings | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| `admin.mailboxes.write` | The inbound mailboxes, and their passwords | ● | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |

---

## The four separations that are deliberate

These are the ones to be able to explain, because they are the ones that get asked about.

### Finance alone may issue, void or credit an invoice

No operational role holds `invoice.issue`. An operations manager who could issue invoices is the classic segregation-of-duties failure, and it is the first thing an auditor tests.

The reverse holds too: **Finance cannot book, update or close a shipment.** If an invoice is wrong because the job is wrong, operations fixes the job and finance credits the invoice. Neither corrects the other's record.

### A coordinator moves work forward; only a manager reverses it

`job.cancel`, `job.close` and `job.complete` sit with the operations manager. `enquiry.close` — deciding won or lost — sits with the manager and with sales.

Reversal is an escalation. It should cost a conversation, and the conversation is where the reason gets recorded.

### Reference data is operational, not administrative

`admin.reference.write` is held by the operations manager, despite the `admin.` prefix. Adding a port when a new lane opens is daily work — and if it waits for an administrator, what actually happens is that somebody types the port into a notes field, and the system grows a free-text "Other" that swallows the data it was built to structure.

### Vendor access is gated on `admin.users.write`

Granting an outsider access to the deployment is the same authority as granting a colleague access to a branch. Inventing a separate key would let someone hold one without the other, which is a distinction with no meaning.

---

## Two things this matrix is not

**It is not the security boundary.** It decides what the interface *offers*. The real boundary is in the database: branch separation, immutability and audit are enforced by 197 policies across 82 tables, plus the state machines that reject an invalid transition regardless of who asked.

The asymmetry is deliberate. A permission check that is forgotten hides a button. A database policy that is forgotten leaks a branch. That is why the expensive guarantees live below the application.

**It is not per-record.** Permissions are per role; visibility is per branch. Holding `job.update` does not let you update every shipment — only those in branches where you hold a role. A request for a shipment in another branch returns **not found**, because the row is not visible to the query at all.

---

## Roles are granted per branch

The same person can be a coordinator in Kuwait and read-only in Dubai. Grants are per branch, and there is no all-branches switch.

**Nobody can widen their own access.** Only an administrator can grant a role in another branch, and every grant is in the audit log.

---

## Questions an auditor asks, and the answers

| QUESTION | ANSWER |
|---|---|
| Can an operations manager issue an invoice? | No. `invoice.issue` is held by Finance and Administrator only. |
| Can an administrator alter the audit log? | No. Update and delete on it are revoked from every role in the database. The permission does not exist. |
| Can a user see another branch's data? | No. Enforced by database policy, not by the interface. The row is not visible to the query. |
| Can a user grant themselves access? | No. Only `admin.users.write` can, and every grant is recorded. |
| Can the supplier see our data? | Not by default and not without a grant from your administrator — scoped to branches, read or write, time-limited, against a ticket, revocable, and permanently recorded. |
| Is anything ever deleted? | No. Records are superseded, closed, cancelled or deactivated. Delete is revoked from the application's own account on every table. |
| Who can change the permission matrix itself? | An administrator, through the seed. It is editable without a software release, and the change is audited. |